

GODAVARI BRIDGE

The River Godavari has the distinction of having three distinct bridges spanning its breadth, each built during different periods of the 20th century. For the railway builders of colonial India, this may have seemed like an inevitable task. After all, the Godavari was one of the longest rivers in the country at 1,465 km, traversing four states before making its way to the Bay of Bengal.

The first, Havelock or the old Godavari Bridge, which was designed by British engineer FTG Walton, came up in 1900 at Rajahmundry in Andhra Pradesh. The 2,950-m-long masonry pier and steel girder bridge served rail traffic along the Chennai–Howrah line.

The second bridge was commissioned after India's Independence during the Third Five Year Plan (1961–66) when most of the Chennai–Howrah track was doubled, barring the Kovvur–Rajahmundry stretch, which required bridging the 3-km-wide river. The local population's demand for a road bridge led to the construction of the Kovvur–Rajahmundry Bridge in 1974. The double-decked, steel girder bridge caters to road and rail traffic. The bridge was constructed using the pneumatic well technique. While the lower deck functions as a single-track rail link between Rajahmundry and Kovvur, the road deck running on top of the girders provides passage to cars. At the time of its construction, it was the longest rail–road bridge in the country, a position now usurped by the Bogibeel Bridge over the River Brahmaputra in Assam.

The unique Godavari Arch Bridge, opened for rail traffic in 1997. It replaced the Havelock Bridge nearby, which was decommissioned the same year after being operational for nearly 100 years. Built with prestressed concrete with a bow-string arch girder superstructure, the 2,745-m arch bridge has 28 spans of about 97 m each.